

# Chicago Tribune



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Rachelle Catayong of Andersonville, from left, Mario Catayong of Lakeview and Michael Panahon of Pilsen cheer while watching the Bears defense get an interception against the Packers on Sunday at Murphy's Bleachers in Chicago's Lakeview neighborhood. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/TRIBUNE**

## Even with loss to Packers, Bears fans are celebrating

Surprising winning season has changed the vibe for those watching rivalry game

By **Adriana Pérez**  
Chicago Tribune

With bated breath and a sense of cautious optimism, Bears fans braved the biting cold to descend on Chicago sports bars Sunday and see their team take on the Green Bay Packers — a match that would end in a loss of the division lead for the Bears but still leave them in a strong playoff position during a surprising first winning season since 2018.

**INSIDE**  
Bears lose nail-biter to rival in Green Bay, fall out of NFC North lead. **Chicago Sports**

Even after the Packers scored their second touchdown of the afternoon in the second quarter, Bears fan Rachelle Catayong wasn't too worried. She sat at the bar at Murphy's Bleachers in Wrigleyville, its walls covered in baseball memorabilia, ornaments

and Christmas lights. "The fourth quarter is the only quarter that matters," she said. This season, the Bears have shown a knack for winning close games with last-minute plays that have clinched victories. On Sunday, they stayed somewhat true to that pattern, catching up to the Packers 21-21 in the final quarter, only to be beaten 21-28. Catayong's cousin, Chicago native Mario Catayong, remembers watching the Bears win the

1986 Super Bowl. He's unsure whether he'll see it happen again this season — but there is reason for hope. "I feel more optimistic than most years," he laughed. Defense can be hit-or-miss, but offense has improved, he said, including quarterback Caleb Williams, in his second season with the Bears. Mario Catayong said he attributes the team's

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## Cardenas fighting to stay on ballot

Challenge to petition signatures threatens political veteran's spot

By **A.D. Quig**  
Chicago Tribune

George Cardenas has been a fixture in Southwest Side politics for decades, a consummate insider who followed five Chicago City Council election wins with another victory that took him to the obscure but powerful Cook County Board of Review. But now he finds himself in a fight befitting a novice, after a challenge to the petition signatures his campaign collected left him 273 short of what he needs to run for reelection in March's Democratic primary. On Friday, seated across from a foot-tall stack of evidence, his legal team began the painstaking, line-by-line rebuttal to try to claw Cardenas' way back onto the ballot.

In cutthroat Cook County politics, gathering good petition signatures is the first hurdle for any would-be candidate. It's a campaign organizational test that tends to reward longtime elected officials who can lean on employees and volunteers they've built up over the years to do the shoe leather work on their behalf.

Cardenas and challenger Juanita Irizarry need 4,941 valid signatures to get on the ballot. Rather than a clash of ideas or an appeal to voters, elections like this one are often decided by arguments between lawyers in fluorescent-lit rooms over whether names scrawled on sheets are legitimate.

For Cardenas, who rose up through one of the most vaunted political operations in the city's

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## Illinois scientists: Versatile grass 'emerging as a force'

Miscanthus could be used for sustainable fuel, building materials, more

By **Adriana Pérez**  
Chicago Tribune

When you look across a field of miscanthus, it's "hypnotically beautiful," says Emily Heaton, whose family farm has for two decades grown the first commercial field of this grass in Illinois. Dense, sun-loving and often called "giant," it blooms in late summer to fall with a showy silver flower. Just like cornstalks across the Midwest, this crop grows several feet tall as it reaches up to the sky. And similar to soybean cultivation in the last century, annual production of miscanthus — mostly grown on tens of thousands of acres in the eastern U.S. — is projected to skyrocket to millions of acres by 2050. The versatile grass has a multitude of end products and uses, including compostable packaging, livestock bedding and erosion control. It can also be used as a solid fuel for electricity and heating, like coal, wood and municipal waste. Scientists are hoping it will open doors to new markets, such as renewable natural

gas, sustainable aviation fuel, building materials, and chemicals for household and industrial products. One variety in particular, *Miscanthus x giganteus*, has demonstrated "unsurpassed productivity" in the Midwest, according to researchers. "Miscanthus is a really exciting crop that's just on the cusp of emerging as a force of the ag-bio-tech sector," said Heaton, a professor of crop sciences at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. "As someone who grew up in Illinois, in downstate Illinois, I'm very excited about the opportunities this brings for rural job creation, for rural technology development and community enhancement." And it has a smaller carbon footprint than the two row crops that have for decades dominated agriculture in Illinois. Researchers, growers and industry experts believe in the crop's potential to strengthen U.S. energy independence, a mission the Trump administration has, for the most part, used to roll back renewable and clean energy incentives, investment and research. It also presents an opportunity for farmers who,

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### 'Nutcracker' keeps improving itself

Joffrey Ballet production, now in its 10th year, tweaks choreography, arrangements and sets to deliver its best version yet at the Lyric Opera House. **Arts & Living**

### Irish won't play bowl game after CFP snub

Amid "shock" of being left out of the 12-team playoff field, Notre Dame announces it is withdrawing from consideration for a bowl game. **Chicago Sports**



Kimberly Steffes asks son Trevor Woodrum, 8, who has Down syndrome, if he wants to sing a song while waiting for his bus to take him to school on Friday at their home in Joliet. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/TRIBUNE**

## Local parents, disability advocates condemn Trump's use of 'R-word'

Researchers find its general use rises after public figures say it

By **Angie Leventis Lourgos**  
Chicago Tribune

The sight of the slur shocked and alarmed the mother of a young boy with special needs. Kimberly Steffes of Joliet never imagined a sitting president never would use the "R-word," a derogatory term long reviled by the intellectual disability community and its advocates.

Yet in a Thanksgiving message on Truth Social, President Donald Trump lobbied the anachronistic insult at Minnesota Gov. Tim Walz, calling the former Democratic nominee for vice president "seriously retarded." A few days later, amid a firestorm over the remark, Trump stood by his use of the word when questioned about it by reporters on Air Force One. "If you have a problem with it, you know what, I think there's something wrong with him," Trump responded, referring to

Walz. But to Steffes, the president's casual use of the slur directly harms her 8-year-old son Trevor, who has Down syndrome. It threatens his very acceptance in society that she and others have been working so hard over the years to forge. Language, she argues, is inextricably linked to real-world barriers, outcomes and opportunities for her child and others with intellectual disabilities. "For those that think it's OK

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